Journal

J.D. Miller
Saltillo, Mexico
8 – 12 November 2011

Saltillo, Mexico, 8-12 November 2011

At the invitation of Professor Jose Parga, former student at the University of Utah (Ph.D. 1987), travel to and accommodations in Saltillo, Mexico were organized for me to give the Keynote Lecture for the 33rd International Congress on Metallurgy and Materials, 9-11 November 2011. Jose completed his PhD at the University of Utah under my supervision in 1987. Since that time he has served on the Metallurgy and Materials faculty at the Saltillo Institute of Technology, a federal government institute, and has been very successful, having a distinguished career. His research students have been recognized at the national level on several occasions. Jose, himself, has also been recognized for his research and teaching skills. For example, in May 2007 he received the 2007 Education Award of the State of Coahuila, Mexico, from the Coahuila Governor.

Tuesday 8, November 2011

After Xuming dropped me at the SLC airport, I discovered that my American Airlines flight to Monterrey through Dallas was cancelled. Fortunately, I was able to convince the desk at AA to book me on a Continental flight to Monterrey through Houston arriving at about the same time of 7:45 pm. Praise the Lord. I asked Evelyn Wells, department assistant, to notify Jose of the change in plans and that I would see him at the Monterrey airport. After an air traffic delay in Houston we finally made it to Monterrey, but no Jose at the gate to meet me. I was able to persuade an Aero Mexico attendant to phone Jose, "Donde esta Jose ?" Jose eventually arrived explaining that he never got the message from Evelyn and that he was waiting in a restaurant with Jesus Valenzuela, another student under my supervision at the University of Utah, who is now Director of the Engineering Division at the University of Sonora in Hermosillo. We drove about 1 hour west from Monterrey to Saltillo, but before reaching Saltillo, on the outskirts of the city, we had to turn around abruptly on the freeway, against traffic, because of a gang shooting. What an exciting arrival in Saltillo. We finally made it to the Camino Real hotel, learning the next day that Policia had apprehended the gang members responsible for the killing.

Wednesday, 9 November 2011

Jesus and I had breakfast at the Camino Real and then travelled with Jose to Saltillo Institute of Technology for the Opening Ceremony of the 33rd International Congress on Metallurgy and Materials. The ceremony had brass, drums, and soldiers in parade dress as the national anthem was played and all joined in singing in honor of the nation. After all this pomp and circumstance, I was invited to present the Keynote Lecture, "3D Characterization, Analysis, and Simulation of Multiphase Particulate Systems in Mineral Processing Using X-Ray Computed Tomography." About 200 attended in a nice auditorium theater. Unfortunately, the video clips would not project during my presentation. After lunch at the La Barzas restaurant, we returned to begin the short course, "Technological Innovations for the Recovery of Gold and Silver." Later in the evening we had a chicken dinner at Jose's home which was prepared by Marlene, Jose's wife. The gifts (a book about Utah, a University of Utah pen and some candy from Utah) for the Pargas were delivered tonight. After a short visit Jose took me back to the hotel. I had difficulty getting connected with my email and, consequently, was not able to send any messages.



Opening ceremonies, 33rd International Congress on Metallurgy and Materials, Saltillo Institute of Technology, Saltillo, Mexico

Thursday, 10 November 2011

After breakfast at the Camino Real, Jose took us to the Institute for continuation of the short course. I spoke first this morning on the use of activated carbon for the recovery of gold and silver. The lecture was well received. I was able to get the video clips to run and project on the screen so that made the presentation more interesting. We had lunch at La Brazas again and then travelled to the Museo de Deseriterio. They really have a nice museum here in Saltillo. I was returned to the hotel and had room service for dinner. Reception on CNN has kept me informed of the Penn State sex scandal. Also Albert, Patricia's brother, has provided updates by email. All leaders, the Head Coach, Joe Paterno, the President, Graham Spanier, and others, VP, AD have been fired, dismissed, or resigned.

Friday, 11 November 2011

The final session of the short course was given this morning. At the end I assisted Professor Parga with the distribution of the diplomas. In the afternoon we had a Closing Function at a private club with more authentic Mexican food. The trip has been complete with Mexican cuisine at each meal. So far, so good. During this week there have been many photos, formal and informal. It seems that I have had individual photographs with each student. Tonight we will enjoy a Hondorous dinner prepared by Marlene. Of course during the week there has been much kind recognition and lots of gifts. Tomorrow, I begin the return to SLC at 7 am.



JDM and Mexican students (left to right): Dulce Huerta, Esmeralda Zertuche, Nancy Ezquivel, and Victoria Garcia.

Saturday, 12 November 2011

Professor Parga and his student, Victor, drove me back to Monterrey to catch the morning flight to Dallas. Everything went well and I arrived back in Salt Lake in the afternoon, being collected by Patricia at the SLC International Airport.